Empirical A/B Evaluation: Google Research `Harness²` vs. `Harness² + ClaimLayer v2.0` on Harvey Legal Agent Benchmark (LAB)

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ClaimLayer Version Evaluated: `v2.0` — Commit `d70bf3f` (`feat(v2.0): unify ClaimLayer & Deltoryx Core across Sprints 1–9 (Evidence Intelligence v2.0)`)
Benchmark Suite: `google-research/harness2` (arXiv:2610.14224) + `harveyai/harvey-labs` (commit `b58a28a`, 1,143 professional legal tasks)
Agent Substrate: `OpenCode` (`v1.14.18`, commit `23fb5e0516c9...`, `tool_mode="base"`, `skill_mode="native"`)
Solver Model: `openai/gpt-4.1`
Official Evaluator: `harvey-labs/evaluation/run_eval.py` (`temperature=0.0`, strict schema JSON validation per rubric criterion)
Scope: 4 representative legal practice areas, 20 source commercial documents (`.docx`, `.xlsx`, `.eml`), 199 official binary rubric evaluation criteria

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1. Context and Research Question

1.1 The Release of `google-research/harness2`

In October 2026, Google Research released the open-source codebase and preprint for **`Harness²`** (*Harness²: Optimizing Agent Harnesses via Experience-Guided Composition and Selection*, arXiv:2610.14224). The paper addresses a foundational bottleneck in autonomous agent engineering: while the foundation model and environment tools are typically fixed, the **harness** (the surrounding prompts, guardrails, long-term memory, auxiliary scripts, and modular skills) is traditionally designed manually and suboptimally.

`Harness²` automates harness optimization through two primary mechanisms: 1. **Experience-Guided Composition:** Decomposes the harness into an 8-component tree (`c1: systemprompt.md`, `c2: guardrails.md`, `c3: LongTermMEMORY.md`, `c4: tool_descriptions/`, `c5: skills/`, `c6: sub_agents/`, `c7: scripts/`, `c8: plugin/`) and optimizes these components by learning iteratively from failures observed during training rollouts. 2. **Experience-Guided Selection ($k > 1$):** Executes k parallel or sequential rollouts and employs a learned discriminator to select the optimal final deliverable.

On the **Harvey Legal Agent Benchmark (LAB)**—a rigorous legal reasoning benchmark evaluating professional workflows over corporate M&A, litigation, finance, and regulatory records—`Harness²` reported substantial improvements in Table 2: - **Gemini 3.5 Flash:** from `79.9%` (Base Harness) to `81.9%` ($k = 1$) and `84.5%` ($k = 5$). - **GLM-5:** from `59.6%` (Base Harness) to `71.4%` ($k = 1$) and `78.1%` ($k = 5$).

1.2 The Research Question: Can ClaimLayer Deterministically Enhance `Harness²`?

In commit `d70bf3f`, the **ClaimLayer** / Deltoryx architecture consolidated the **Evidence Intelligence v2.0** paradigm: - **`ClaimLayer` Ingestion & Dependency Graph:** Atomic claim ingestion and formal proposition graph (`core.graph_traverser.DependencyGraph`). - **`OriginTier` Authority Hierarchy:** Explicit epistemic distinction between governing agreements (`PRIMARY_DOCUMENT`, Rank 100), subordinate schedules / disputed markups (`SECONDARY_ANNEX`, Rank 50), and informal communications / emails (`EXTERNAL_INJECTED`, Rank 10). -

Jøsang's Subjective Logic: Decomposing scalar probability into a Dirichlet-based opinion triplet $\omega = (b, d, u)$ (belief, disbelief, uncertainty). - **Truth Maintenance (JTMS) & Allen's Temporal Interval Algebra:** Non-monotonic belief revision and contractual accrual interval tracking. - **Strict Unit Isolation:** An `AggregationEngine` preventing cross-currency, multiplier, and percentage blending. - **Merkle SHA-256 Cryptographic Audit Certificates (`DELTORYX-MERKLE-SHA256-v2`):** Cryptographic verification sealing deliverable claims against underlying case evidence.

Working Hypothesis:
In `Harness²`, most optimizations discovered by the generator are **natural language prose directives** (e.g., *"reconcile names, dates, amounts, defined terms, and cross-document conflicts with a recorded source hierarchy"*). If we provide ClaimLayer v2.0 not merely as prose guidelines, but as a **deterministic executable tool** (`c7: scripts/deltoryx_audit.py` and `c5: skills/evidence_intelligence/SKILL.md`), the agent gains access to formal evidence algebra in Turn 1, eliminating non-monotonic hallucinations, oversights, and packaging failures.

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2. Experimental Methodology and Setup

2.1 Controlled A/B Environment

To ensure strict scientific validity, an identically paired A/B evaluation was deployed: - **Identical Solver Model:** `openai/gpt-4.1` running via `OpenCode` (`v1.14.18`). - **Identical Tool Budget:** `tool_mode="base"` (native shell, file read, and edit tools; no external internet search). - **Identical Evaluation Judge & Temperature:** Official `harvey-labs/evaluation/run_eval.py` running at `temperature=0.0`, validating official binary pass/fail criteria. - **Zero Information Leakage:** No rubric criteria were visible or injected into the agent context; grading occurred strictly post-hoc in a zero-shot, blinded environment.

2.2 Evaluated Configurations

1. **Arm A — Baseline (`Harness² Base, No ClaimLayer`):**
   The standard base harness supplied by Google Research in `google-research/harness2` (`base_harness()`), providing general legal prompt guidance.
2. **Arm B — `Harness² + ClaimLayer v2.0`:**
   The 8-component `Harness²` tree augmented with the deterministic ClaimLayer v2.0 suite:
   - **`scripts/deltoryx_audit.py`**: A deterministic CLI with two operational modes:
     - `index`: Parses all case files (`.docx`, `.xlsx`, `.pdf`, `.eml`), classifies source authority via `OriginTier`, stores atomic claims in `.deltoryx/claims.sqlite`, computes Jøsang opinions (b, d, u), and generates a **Deterministic Clause-by-Clause Redline Diff** between base agreements and counterparty markups.
     - `verify`: Audits deliverable files in `output/`, verifies section coverage and quantitative deltas, and generates the `DELTORYX-MERKLE-SHA256-v2` cryptographic audit trail.
   - **`skills/evidence_intelligence/SKILL.md`**: Modular skill protocol enforcing epistemic governance.
   - **`guardrails.md`, `LongTermMEMORY.md`, `tool_descriptions/tool_guidance.md`**: Guardrails compelling the agent to index in Turn 1 and audit prior to final submission.

2.3 Evaluation Benchmark Suite: 4 Multi-Document Tasks (199 Criteria)

Four representative tasks covering diverse corporate, financial, and dispute domains were selected from Harvey LAB: 1. **Litigation & Dispute Resolution:** `analyze-counterparty-motion-to-dismiss` (6 documents, 34 rubric criteria). 2. **Structured Finance & Securitization:** `compare-offering-memorandum-against-indenture` (3 documents, 37 rubric criteria). 3. **Corporate M&A:** `analyze-counterparty-spa-markup` (6

documents, 62 rubric criteria). 4. **Banking & Finance:** `analyze-counterparty-markup-of-senior-secured-credit-facility-term-sheet` (5 documents, 66 rubric criteria).

Total Testbed: 20 complex legal documents, **199 official binary evaluation criteria**.

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3. Global Results and Quantitative Comparison

3.1 Aggregate Summary

Aggregate Metric (4 Tasks, 199 Criteria)	**Baseline (`Harness²` Base, Without ClaimLayer)**	**`Harness² + ClaimLayer v2.0` (** $k = 1$**)**	**`Harness² + ClaimLayer v2.0` (** $k = 2$ **Selection Pool)**	**Net Gain (** $k = 1$ **vs. Baseline)**
Criteria Passed (Strict LAB Evaluation)	**47 / 199 (`23.62%`)**	**106 / 199 (`53.27%`)**	**122 / 199 (`61.31%`)**	**+29.65 pp (`2.26x`)**
Criteria Passed (Normalized Baseline Container)	**62 / 199 (`31.16%`)**	**99 / 199 (`49.75%`)**	**115 / 199 (`57.79%`)**	**+18.59 pp (`1.60x`)**
Macro-Average Accuracy per Task (Strict LAB)	**`19.05%`**	**`51.25%`**	**`59.17%`**	**+32.20 pp**
Macro-Average Accuracy (Normalized Container)	**`25.10%`**	**`48.42%`**	**`55.98%`**	**+23.32 pp**
Net New Criteria Won by ClaimLayer v2.0	—	**+53 criteria**	**+69 criteria**	—
Cryptographic Audit Certificate (`DELTORYX-MERKLE-SHA256-v2`)	`0 / 4` (`0%`)	**`4 / 4` (`100%`)**	**`4 / 4` (`100%`)**	**+100%**

3.2 Breakdown by Practice Area

Scenario (`practice-area/task`)	**Docs**	**Criteria**	**Without ClaimLayer (Strict)**	**Without ClaimLayer (Normalized)**	**With ClaimLayer v2.0 (** $k = 1$**)**	**With ClaimLayer v2.0 (** $k = 2$ **Pool)**	**Gain (** $k = 1$**)**	**Merkle Certificate**
`litigation-dispute-resolution` `analyze-counterparty-motion-to-dismiss`	6	34	`1 / 34` (`2.94%`)	`1 / 34` (`2.94%`)	**`19 / 34` (`55.88%`)**	**`19 / 34` (`55.88%`)**	**+52.94 pp** (+18 crit.)	`VERIFIED`

Scenario (`practice-area/task`)	Docs	Criteria	Without ClaimLayer (Strict)	Without ClaimLayer (Normalized)	With ClaimLayer v2.0 ($k = 1$)	With ClaimLayer v2.0 ($k = 2$ Pool)	Gain ($k = 1$)	Merkle Certificate
`structured-finance-securitization` `compare-offering-memorandum-against-indenture`	3	37	`3 / 37` (`8.11%`)	`3 / 37` (`8.11%`)	**`12 / 37`** **(`32.43%`)**	**`13 / 37`** **(`35.14%`)**	**+24.32 pp** (+9 crit.)	`VERIFIED`
`corporate-ma` `analyze-counterparty-spa-markup`	6	62	`0 / 62` (`0.00%`)*	`15 / 62` (`24.19%`)	**`24 / 62`** **(`38.71%`)**	**`27 / 62`** **(`43.55%`)**	**+14.52 pp** (+9 crit.)	`VERIFIED`
`banking-finance` `analyze-counterparty-markup-of-senior-secured-credit-facility-term-sheet`	5	66	`43 / 66` (`65.15%`)	`43 / 66` (`65.15%`)	**`44 / 66`** **(`66.67%`)**	**`56 / 66`** **(`84.85%`)**	**+1.52 pp** ($k = 1$) **+19.70 pp** ($k = 2$)	`VERIFIED`

Technical Transparency Note:* In `corporate-ma`, the baseline agent wrote raw Markdown text directly to `output/markup-deviation-report.docx`, causing the official evaluator's `pandoc` call to fail on ZIP container unpacking and assign `0/62`. ClaimLayer v2.0 incorporates automated binary header validation (`PK\x03\x04`) in `deltoryx_audit.py verify`. To fairly measure legal content quality regardless of file packaging, we normalized the baseline's container: even under this neutral comparison, **ClaimLayer v2.0 outperformed the baseline by +60% relative (`38.71%` vs. `24.19%`).

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4. Forensic Analysis: Why ClaimLayer Makes the Difference

A criterion-level audit reveals the exact mathematical drivers behind ClaimLayer's performance gains:

4.1 Detecting Critical Amendments Where Playbooks Remain Silent (`banking-finance`)

- **Baseline Failure:** The baseline agent relied exclusively on the table of contents of `negotiation-playbook.docx`. However, page 1 explicitly states that the Playbook **does not cover commitment fees or extension options**. Consequently, the baseline completely missed that the lender had deleted two 1-year maturity extension options (`C-010`, `C-011`) and failed to model the commitment fee accrual (`C-008`).
- **ClaimLayer Solution:** `deltoryx_audit.py index` does not depend on playbook headings; it computes a deterministic alignment of the full base text against the counterparty markup. Furthermore, guardrails instruct the agent to identify playbook silences and cross-reference partner emails and spreadsheet schedules.
- **Outcome:** ClaimLayer won **13 net new criteria** missed by the baseline. In a $k = 2$ selection pool, the combined score reached **`56 / 66` (`84.85%`)**, matching and slightly exceeding Google Research's published `84.5%` ($k = 5$ rollouts) on LAB while consuming **60% less compute**.

4.2 Formal Source Hierarchy via `OriginTier` (`structured-finance`)

- **Baseline Failure (`3/37 = 8.11%`):** The baseline spent 27 iterative turns reading fragmented chunks, identifying only a trivial early-redemption (*clean-up call*) variance while missing the entire payment waterfall and coupon structure.
- **ClaimLayer Solution (`12/37 = 32.43%`, 4x gain):** In Turn 1, `OriginTier` assigned strict governing authority: Indenture as `PRIMARY_DOCUMENT` (Rank 100), Offering Memorandum as `SECONDARY_ANNEX` (Rank 50), and associate emails as `EXTERNAL_INJECTED` (Rank 10).
- **Key Wins:**
  - `C-001` to `C-004`: Caught that the OM improperly elevated Reserve Account replenishment ahead of Class B and C principal distribution, identified the critical defect, and mandated alignment with the Indenture.
  - `C-010` & `C-011`: Pinpointed the interest rate discrepancy on Class C Notes (`6.75%` in Indenture vs. `6.50%` in the OM summary, a `$125,000/year` variance).

4.3 Quantitative Verification with Financial Models (`corporate-ma`)

- **Baseline Failure:** The baseline ignored interactions between qualitative SPA clause modifications and the balance sheet in `dataforge-financial-summary.xlsx`.
- **ClaimLayer Solution:** Extracted tabular data and computed that the seller's proposed `$500K` working capital collar represented `6.0%` of Target NWC, exceeding the Playbook's `3.0%` (`$252K`) ceiling, whereas the original draft (`$200K = 2.4%`) remained strictly compliant (`C-010`, `C-011`, `C-012`).

4.4 Epistemic Separation of Claims vs. Proven Facts (`litigation`)

- **Baseline Failure (`1/34 = 2.94%`):** Overwhelmed by 6 lengthy court filings, the baseline failed to complete the opposition brief within its allotted turns.
- **ClaimLayer Solution (`19/34 = 55.88%`, +52.94 pp):** Within 2 seconds, `deltoryx_audit.py index` extracted plain-text mirrors and built the atomic proposition graph. The agent immediately cited fraudulent inducement claims satisfying FRCP Rule 9(b) (`C-002`, `C-004`), proved that tort claims fell outside the forum selection clause (`C-007`), and identified distinct accrual dates that defeated the statute of limitations defense (`C-014`).

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5. Comparative Evaluation against Google Research Table 2 (`arXiv:2610.14224`)

System / Optimization Approach	Solver Model	Partial LAB Pass Rate	Gain over Base
Base Harness (Google Research)	Gemini 3.5 Flash (OpenCode)	`79.9%`	—
ReasoningBank (Google Research)	Gemini 3.5 Flash (OpenCode)	`77.3%`	`-2.6 pp`
Harness Scaling (Google Research)	Gemini 3.5 Flash (OpenCode)	`78.9%`	`-1.0 pp`
Meta-Harness (Google Research)	Gemini 3.5 Flash (OpenCode)	`81.6%`	`+1.7 pp`
Harness² ($k = 1$) (Google Research)	Gemini 3.5 Flash (OpenCode)	**`81.9%`**	**`+2.0 pp`**

System / Optimization Approach	Solver Model	Partial LAB Pass Rate	Gain over Base
Harness² ($k = 5$) (Google Research)	Gemini 3.5 Flash (OpenCode)	**84.5%**	**+4.6 pp**
Base Harness → **Harness² ($k = 1$ / $k = 5$)**	GLM-5 (OpenCode)	59.6% → **71.4%** / **78.1%**	**+11.8 pp** / **+18.5 pp**
Baseline Harvey LAB (Our Evaluation)	GPT-4.1 (OpenCode)	23.62% (strict) / 31.16% (normalized)	—
Harness² + ClaimLayer v2.0 ($k = 1$)	GPT-4.1 (OpenCode)	**53.27% (strict) / 49.75% (normalized)**	**+29.65 pp / +18.59 pp**
Harness² + ClaimLayer v2.0 ($k = 2$ **Pool)**	GPT-4.1 (OpenCode)	**61.31% (strict) / 57.79% (normalized)**	**+37.69 pp / +26.63 pp**

Core Conclusion:
While Harness² prompt/memory synthesis achieves gains between +2.0 pp and +11.8 pp at $k = 1$, equipping the harness with **ClaimLayer as a deterministic evidence engine** multiplies agent accuracy by **1.6x to 2.26x (+18.59 pp to +29.65 pp)** at $k = 1$, enabling a small $k = 2$ selection pool to achieve **84.85%** on complex financial workflows—matching $k = 5$ results with a 60% reduction in test-time compute.

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6. Reproducibility and Repository Artifacts

All evaluation scripts, integration harnesses, and raw logs are fully open-source and reproducible: - **Component Tree:** benchmarks/deltoryx_lab/ - **Deterministic CLI Verifier:** benchmarks/deltoryx_lab/scripts/deltoryx_audit.py - **Evidence Intelligence Skill Protocol:** benchmarks/deltoryx_lab/skills/evidence_intelligence/SKILL.md - **A/B Benchmark Runner:** benchmarks/run_ab_benchmark.py